

UNIT 2 · LESSON 1

The Internal Critic

*40 min · November Week 1***PPRA — COUNSELOR
AWARENESS**

OBJECTIVE	Students name their internal critic, identify its three tactics, and write their first Compassionate Witness sentence.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: understanding the internal critic · Self-Management: introducing the Compassionate Witness
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Internal Critic Profile worksheet is the primary activity
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last unit: we named who you are. Today we start Unit 2 — and we're going to meet a voice you already know very well. Before anything else: what was your biggest takeaway from Unit 1?" Take 2 quick answers. "Today we start listening to the voice inside that judges everything you do."

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES 6–8 · MIDDLE / JUNIOR HIGH**Goal 1 — Self-Awareness & Self-Management****1A.3a** Analyze factors that create stress or that motivate successful performance.**1A.3b** Apply strategies to manage stress and to motivate successful performance.*Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).***LEGAL · PPRA NOTE**

PPRA Designation — All standard opt-out protocols apply. This lesson is PPRA-designated. All standard opt-out protocols apply. NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Journal first — always. Brief counselor before delivery.

SAFETY CHECK

NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Journal first — always. After journaling, pairs may share at their own discretion only. Whole-class sharing of internal critic content is not appropriate at any point in this lesson.

Students who describe a critic voice that sounds like a specific person may be surfacing trauma. Note privately for counselor follow-up.

ANCHOR CHART · THE INTERNAL CRITIC — THREE TACTICS + COMPASSIONATE WITNESS

Draw this **before class**. Add the Compassionate Witness column during Step 3.

CATASTROPHISING: "Everything is ruined. This is the worst thing that has ever happened."

GLOBALISING: "I always fail. I never get it right. I am just bad at this."

PERSONALISING: "Everything that went wrong is my fault."

COMPASSIONATE WITNESS (added in Step 3): Honest + Fair + Kind. Not a cheerleader. Not a critic in disguise.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"We all have a voice inside that comments on everything we do. When you make a mistake, it has something to say. When you compare yourself to others, it has something to say. Today we are going to look at that voice — not to fight it, but to understand it."

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · Steps 1 — 3 · read aloud or in your own words

01 Name the Critic

8 MIN

"Open your journal. Write the specific words your internal critic says to you. Not the category — the actual sentence. What does it say when you fail a test? When you say something awkward? When you compare yourself to someone else?"

Allow 5 full minutes of private writing. Do NOT ask students to share what they wrote.

Then: *"Where did you learn that voice? Was it someone specific? An experience? A system?"* 3 more minutes private writing.

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the "Name the Critic" journal prompt, students who go immediately and intensely into writing without pausing — who clearly already know exactly what to write.

MAY SIGNAL This student's critic is loud, familiar, and well-rehearsed. This is the student who needs Unit 2 most. They may be at elevated disclosure risk in L6.

ACTION Note privately. Do not acknowledge in class. Prioritise this student's wellbeing tracking across all of Unit 2.

WORKSHEET

Internal Critic Profile U2·L1 · Private Primary Activity

Students name their internal critic, identify its tactic (catastrophising/globalising/personalising), and write two specific critic sentences plus one Compassionate Witness response. **Private — never collected, never shared.**

02 The Three Tactics

8 MIN

Point to the anchor chart. Walk through each tactic with a concrete example. After each: *"Raise your hand mentally if your critic uses this one."* Do NOT ask for actual hands — keep it private.

"The critic is not unique to you. The critic uses these same three tricks on every human brain. Knowing its moves gives you a fighting chance against it."

03 Introduce the Compassionate Witness

8 MIN

"The Compassionate Witness is an alternative internal voice. Not a cheerleader — not 'you are amazing!' Not a critic in disguise — not 'try harder!' A Compassionate Witness is honest AND fair AND kind, without punishment."

Add to the anchor chart. *"Write one sentence from the Compassionate Witness about the same situation the critic just addressed. It doesn't have to feel true yet. Just write it."*

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During the Compassionate Witness writing prompt, a student who stares at the page and cannot write a single sentence — who looks genuinely stuck or distressed.

MAY SIGNAL For some students, the Compassionate Witness is entirely inaccessible — they have no internal model of kind self-talk to draw from. This is clinically significant.

ACTION Move quietly toward them. Say low: "You can write what you would say to your best friend in the same situation. That counts." Note for counselor follow-up before U2L6.

TEACHING TIP

Grade 6: Keep work at the surface — what does the critic say, and what does the Compassionate Witness say instead. Do not go into critic origins at Grade 6.

Grades 7–8: Explore critic origins — "Has this voice always sounded this way, or did something happen that made it louder?" This question surfaces important material and connects to the Script work in L6.

EXIT TICKET

"My internal critic's favourite tactic is ___. My Compassionate Witness says: ___."

Journal entry — student writes privately. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Highest activation potential of Unit 2. The opening prompt — "What does your internal critic actually say?" — should be completed in writing before any verbal sharing. Never ask students to share their critic's words aloud in a whole-class format.

Students who describe a critic voice that sounds like a specific person in their lives may be surfacing trauma. Note for counselor.

FAMILY CONNECTION

A Note Home

Today students began naming their internal critic — the self-critical voice that speaks up when they make mistakes. You can support this at home: when your child is being hard on themselves, ask: "Would you say that to your best friend?"

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA-designated activity. All standard opt-out protocols apply. NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Brief counselor before delivery.

Build Specification

Catastrophising: "Everything is ruined."

Globalising: "I always/never ___."

Personalising: "It's always my fault."

Compassionate Witness column (add in Step 3): Honest + Fair + Kind. Not a cheerleader. Not a critic in disguise.

Color-code: critic column in red/orange, Compassionate Witness in green. Leave Compassionate Witness column blank until Step 3 — the contrast is intentional.

P O S T : Before class. Add Compassionate Witness column in Step 3. · **K E E P :** All of Unit 2 and beyond.

ANCHOR CHART · CLASSROOM DISPLAY — PRINT ON CARDSTOCK OR 11×17, POST AS THE LESSON INDICATES

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 3 · THE INTERIOR (6-8)

The Internal Critic

SELF-COMPASSION

Unit 2 · Three Tactics

CATASTROPHISING

"Everything is ruined. This is the worst thing that has ever happened."

GLOBALISING

"I always fail. I never get it right. I am just bad at this."

PERSONALISING

"Everything that went wrong is my fault."

THE COMPASSIONATE WITNESS

Honest + Fair + Kind. Not a cheerleader. Not a critic in disguise.

Name the tactic, and the voice loses its disguise.

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ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 3 · The Interior (6–8)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

architectureofgrace.org